

WEALTH

RICH PICKINGS

This Lok Sabha witnesses the largest number of crorepatists across parties, which suggests that we are seeing a new breed of politician

Money talks. This is the richest Parliament ever. Money power has always played a major role in every election but this time individuals with deep pockets will dominate the House with over 300 MPs having assets worth over a crore getting the thumbs up from the voters. While it may not be representative of a country where millions live in poverty, this could be a sign that either long-term MPs are getting richer pretty fast or that politics has started to attract people from the wealthier classes. The average assets for MPs for most parties have increased, even rivalling the best of the stock market bull runs. The average assets for a Congress MP in 2004 was 3.4 crore which is now 6.86 crore. For the BJP, it was 1.2 crore and is 3.06 crore now.

The Congress has acquired the maximum number of crorepatists (137), followed by BJP (58), SP (14) and BSP (13). The richest Parliamentarian is Namma Nageswara Rao from Andhra Pradesh, a Telugu Desam Party (TDP) member. His declared assets are Rs 173 crore. The poverty of the voter is not always reflected in their choice. Uttar Pradesh, the state with highest number of people below poverty line, has also sent to the Lok Sabha 52 crorepatists, followed by Maharashtra (37), Andhra Pradesh (31) and Karnataka (25). But money power, of course, is not the surest way to Parliament Street. The richest candidate in the Lok Sabha fray—V.M. Singh, the Congress nominee from Pilibhit with a declared net worth of Rs 632.15 crore—failed to make it to Parliament. The trend is largely positive considering that more affluent members should ideally translate into less corruption in government functioning, as has been evident in developed countries.



NAMMA NAGESWARA RAO
Andhra Pradesh, Khammam
TDP
173 crore



PADMASINH BAJIRAO PATIL
Maharashtra, Osmanabad
NCP
105 crore



NAVEEN JINDAL
Haryana, Kurukshetra
INC
127 crore



PRAFUL PATEL
Maharashtra, Bhandara
NCP
89 crore

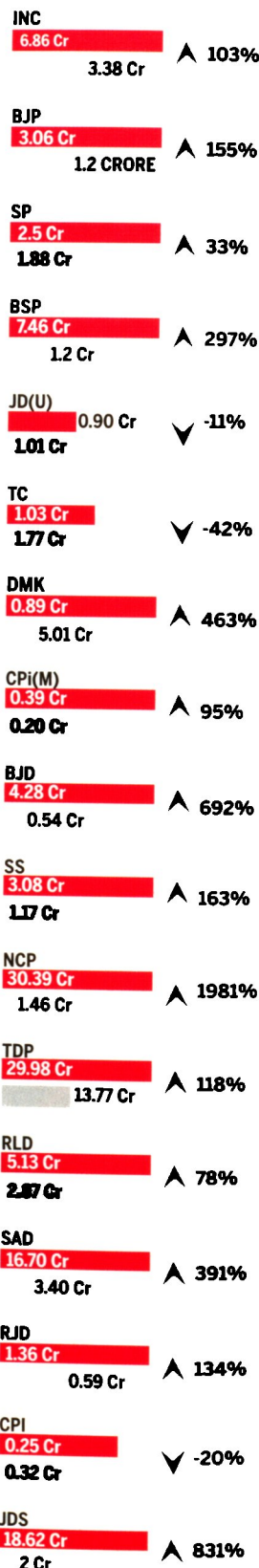


L. RAJAGOPAL
Andhra Pradesh,
Vijayawada
INC
122 crore

THE AVERAGE ASSETS FOR MPs FROM MOST PARTIES HAS INCREASED QUITE DRAMATICALLY

ASSET MULTIPLIER

Politicians are bucking the meltdown. The assets of MPs of some parties have gone up by over 2,000%*.



* The value of assets per MP. Source: ADR and NE Watch.